did as they were asked. To their surprise and to mine, the maharaja told them not to keep an army officer waiting outside, and we were quickly escorted in. We entered the residential property; it was even more beautiful from the inside. The Italian marble flooring, ornate accessories, lavish Persian carpets, shining chandeliers and rare antiquities from various parts of the world, displayed along the pathways, were mesmerizing. We were taken to a small garden, where chairs had already been laid out for us to sit on. Stewards worked carefully to place silver crockery, including cups, saucers and a teapot, on a small round glass table. We were asked to sit and wait there. In another two minutes, the maharaja came to meet us. Papaji stood up and I imitated him. His Highness shook hands with Papaji.

'Thank you for letting us in,' Papaji said.

'It is my honour to have an army officer in my residence,' replied the humble and charming maharaja who was dressed in an embroidered white kurta pyjama. 'Let's have a cup of tea before we discuss what brings you here.'

I had imagined someone wearing an enormous crown on his head and a bundle of necklaces jangling on his torso. But he had a shaved face, neatly cut hair and was wearing a pair of spectacles. His plain manners complemented his reputation.

'So what bothers you, Major?' he asked Papaji after the basic introductions were dealt with.

'I want to buy a car that once belonged to you,' Papaji replied plainly. As if having a cup of tea with the maharaja was not enough. If I had been in his place, I would have dropped all my other wishes. But I was amazed at Papaji's determination and straightforwardness. The maharaja was rather amused.

'You have come all the way on your scooter to buy a car that belongs to me?' he said with a smile. 'Why?'

'Because it's a rare model and it belongs to you,' Papaji replied honestly. 'I'm talking about the 1951 Studebaker Champion I saw at a garage.'

'Oh, that one,' His Highness said. 'Forgive me, but I can't sell that one. I have a collection of other cars you can choose from.' I thought it was a